Birdcage: The Shooting Script

By Elaine May

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

CHARACTERS – SUGGESTED ROLES:

ACTOR 1: Albert, the Man
ACTOR2: Armand, Agador

- ***Armand Goldman:*** *The openly gay owner of a drag club called The Birdcage*
- ***Albert:*** *An extremely effeminate and flamboyant man, the star attraction of the club.*
- ***Agador:*** *Their flamboyant Guatemalan housekeeper.*
- ***Man:*** *Generic man on the street – tough and ready to fight (The atypical New Yorker)*

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Open with Albert singing the beginning of "Little Dream" by Stephen Sondheim on the Birdcage Stage . . . . (listen to the lyrics as https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WiybXEgwTCQ)

ALBERT: *(singing)* What is this dream I see? Why does it seems so real to me? What if this dream turns out to be, more than a dream . . . . *(stops singing to complain to Armand about one of the backup dancers)* Well this is impossible, either I'm an artist, or I'm just some cheap drag queen - playing it straight so **he** can get laughs. I mean he's chewing gum! *(p. 29, scene 36)*

ARMAND: Let's just try and get through it . . . *(p. 29, scene 36)*

ALBERT: Armand, you always ask so much of me. I have to understand every nuance of a song. I have to rehearse in full costume. But everyone else can just get through it. *(p. 29, scene 36)*

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ARMAND: All right, let's take it from the top . . . no more talking . . . from anyone. *(p. 29, scene 36)*

ALBERT: Armand, did you see what he did? He blew a bubble with his gum. While I was singing. He can't do that while I'm singing. *(p. 30, scene 36) (storms off stage to the dressing room)*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Armand and Albert are in a committed,*
ACTOR 2: *although un-conventional,*
ACTOR 1: *relationship.*
ACTOR 2: *95 percent of the time they don't worry about how they are viewed by the world.*
ACTOR 1: *They are comfortable as the owner and star of the Birdcage,*
ACTOR 2: *a drag club with a fantastic stage show!*
ACTOR 1: *But when Armand's son springs wedding plans on them, their unconventional life must suddenly appear to be quite conventional.*
ACTOR 2: *The potential in-laws are the ultraconservative Republican Senator Kevin Keeley and his wife Louise.*
ACTOR 1: *In this selection Albert tries his best to vanquish his inner drag queen.*
TOGETHER: *Birdcage: The Shooting Script by Elaine May.*

AGADOR: *(walks into room…holds out high heels and stockings).* Just put these on. Please. *(p. 3, scene 6)*

ALBERT: No, Agador. (Albert) will not dance the dance of the red shoes tonight. Or any other night. *(p. 3, scene 6)*

AGADOR: Just the stockings. *(p. 3, scene 6)*

ALBERT: (Albert) is dead. *(p. 3, scene 6)*

AGADOR: Just this stocking? *(p. 3, scene 6)*

ALBERT: Do you know how she died? Alone. Weeping for her lover. For each man kills the thing he loves . . . *(p. 4, scene 6) (Armand knocks insistently on the door)*

AGADOR: Let's open the door for (Armand), shall we? Let's be nice. *(p. 4, scene 8)*

ALBERT: No. I don't want him to see me. I'm hideous. *(p. 4, scene 8)* Fat and hideous. *(p. 5, scene 8)*

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AGADOR: I know. *(p. 5, scene 8)*

ALBERT: Oh, Agador I'm in such pain . . . *(p. 5, scene 8)*

AGADOR: I know. It will pass . . . *(p. 5, scene 8)*

ALBERT: It will never pass. I hate my life . . . *(p. 5, scene 8)* Whatever I am he made me. I was adorable once. Young and full of hope. Now I'm this short, fat, middle aged, insecure thing. *(p. 6, scene 8)*

ARMAND: *(suddenly appearing in the doorway)* I made you short? Do I send Carmen on (to do your number)? *(p. 6, scene 8)*

ALBERT: No! How dare you! *(p. 6, scene 8)*

ARMAND: Yes! *(p. 6, scene 8)*

ALBERT: Please! I'll go on. Don't give my number away! I'll be good. *(p. 6, scene 8)*

ARMAND: All right! *(p. 7, scene 8)*

ALBERT: My hands are shaking. Agador I need some Pirin tablets. Quickly. *(p. 7, scene 8)*

AGADOR: Here. One before the show and one after. But no more. *(p. 7, scene 8)*

ALBERT: Thank you, my darling Agador. *(p. 7, scene 8)*

ARMAND: *(pulling Agador to the side)* What are you doing? Why are you giving him drugs? What the hell are Pirin tablets? *(p. 7, scene 9)*

AGADOR: They're Aspirin with the "a" and the "s" scraped off. *(p. 7, scene 9)*

ARMAND: My God! What a brilliant idea. *(p. 7, scene 9)*

TRANSITION

ACTOR 1: *And as if the pressure of the nightly drag-extravaganza isn't enough . . . Armand soon reveals some new news. News that only adds to Albert's stress level . . .*

ARMAND: (Albert, my sons') fiancée is coming tonight -- with her parents. And we . . . we thought . . . it would be better if you weren't here. *(p. 43, scene 55)* This is not because of <u>you.</u> This is because this girl's parents are a**h****. *(p. 45, scene 56)*

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ALBERT: Oh. I understand. It's just while people are here. It's nothing. It's painful, but it's not important. I'm leaving. The monster is leaving. I'm leaving. You're safe. *(walks out) (turn) (p. 44, scene 55)* (Oh, Armand,) My heart is breaking *(turn left) (p. 44, scene 56)*

ARMAND: *(puts hand on ALBERT'S shoulder)* Oh, God. Please. Don't cry. It's all right. You can stay. *(p. 44, scene 56)*

ALBERT: Maybe . . . *(picks up a teacup and takes a sip, pinky up in proper British form)* maybe it is too much to introduce me as his mother on the first visit. *(sip)* Could you tell them I was his uncle? Uncle Al? *(p. 46, scene 56)*

ARMAND: *(Big pause and sigh)* Oh, f*** 'em! Of course, you can pass as an uncle. You're a great performer. And I'm a great director! Together we can do . . . almost anything. We have *(looks at watch)* five hours. First - your pinky. It's up again. Get it down. And stand up straight. *(p. 46, scene 56)*

ALBERT: *(jumps)* Oh! My God! What are you doing? *(p. 47, scene 56)*

ARMAND: I'm teaching you to be a man. Now this is a dinner party so let's work with the food. Spread some mustard on that bread. Not with the spoon. Don't dribble little dots of mustard on. Take the knife and smear. Men smear. *(p. 47, scene 56)*

ALBERT: *(smear mustard on bread with tongue out)* Oh, God! I've pierced the toast! *(p. 47, scene 56)*

ARMAND: So what? The important thing is not to go to pieces when that happens. React the way a man would. Calmly. Just say to yourself, "Albert, you pierced the toast. So what? Your life isn't over." Try another one. *(hands ALBERT another piece of toast) (p. 47, scene 56)*

ALBERT: *(takes toast)* You're right, you're right. There's no need to get hysterical. All I have to remember is that I can always get more toast. *(p. 47, scene 56)*

ARMAND: That's the spirit. Now let's see you walk. *(p. 47,scene 56) (Albert walks)*

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ALBERT: Holding the sandwich? *(p. 47, scene 56)*

ARMAND: It doesn't matter, just walk. *(p. 47, scene 56)*

ALBERT *(turn)* Too swishy? *(p. 47 scene 56)*

ARMAND: Let me give you an image. John Wayne. *(p. 47, scene 56)* He had a very distinctive walk and if anyone was a man . . . Just get off your horse and head for the saloon. *(p. 48, scene 56) (Albert walks "John Wayne" style back to center)*

ALBERT: No good? *(p. 48, scene 56)*

ARMAND: Actually . . . it's perfect. I just never realized John Wayne walked that way. *(p. 48, scene 56)* Take it from the top. *(p. 49, scene 59) (Armand bumps into Man)*

MAN: Take it easy. *(p. 49, scene 59)*

ARMAND: You take it easy pilgrim. *(p. 50, scene 59)*

MAN: Well, (you) bumped into me. *(p. 50, scene 59)*

ARMAND: Well, tough gazongas. *(p. 50, scene 59)*

MAN: Why are you being such a pr***? *(p. 50, scene 59)*

ARMAND: Why are you being such an a**h***? *(p. 50, scene 59)*

MAN: *(Standing – he is very large)* Did you just call me an a**h***, a**h***? *(p. 50, scene 59)*

ARMAND: No actually I was talking to the a**h*** behind you. *(p. 50, scene 59)*

Pantomime fight scene ensues between Armand and "the Man" (freeze fight scene, then Actor 1 steps out for transition)

TRANSITION

ACTOR 1 as ALBERT: *Well . . . who would have expected that! These MEN . . . they think that fighting is the answer to everything! (Heavy sigh)*

Albert re-enters scene, with Armand the obvious loser of the fight . . .

ALBERT: See the swelling's already gone down. It's nothing. Very masculine. That big idiot looked so ridiculous when he sat on you and banged your head into the ground. He didn't even know how to box. Are you all right? *(p. 50, scene 60)*

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ARMAND: I hurt my thumb. *(p. 9, scene 10)*

ALBERT: Oh, my god! Forgive me? *(p. 9, scene 10)*

ARMAND: No, no forgive me, my little roundness. My teddy bear. *(p. 9, scene 10)*

ALBERT: My king! *(p. 9, scene 10)*

ARMAND: My queen! *(p. 9, scene 10)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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